imperative. Monserrate had described it as a means by which the Padshah controlled his nobility, who needed to constantly be reminded of their place in the imperial hierarchy. ‘In order to prevent the great nobles becoming insolent through the unchallenged enjoyment of power’, wrote Monserrate, ‘the king summons [them] to court…and gives them many imperious commands, as though they were his slaves—commands, moreover, obedience to which ill suits their exalted rank and dignity’.

Having crossed Ambala, the army reached Sirhind, a large city built on a broad plain ‘beautified by many groves of trees and pleasant gardens’. This was a thriving city where ‘bows, quivers, shoes, greaves and sandals’, were made and exported to all the cities of the empire. There was a famous school of medicine in Sirhind, which exported doctors to other parts of the country. While camped at Sirhind, Akbar received the encouraging news that Mirza Hakim had fled Hindustan, and was heading away from Lahore, back towards Kabul. Intensely relieved by Mirza Hakim’s decision, Akbar went on outings around the city on his favourite two-horse chariot on which, admitted the Jesuits, he looked very imposing. Mirza Hakim would be pursued, Akbar decided, and made to fight or to submit, once and for all.

On their long march across the country, the ordinary soldiers and low-ranking mansabdars kept themselves toned and fit by organizing drills and games. Since amirs did not routinely conduct training manoeuvres, the men exercised on their own to stay in fighting shape, with ‘dumb-bells, heavy sticks of wood, clubs, and chainbows. Daily rehearsal of a coordinated sequence of movements called kasarat developed agility and quickness. The men wrestled and engaged in mock fights with heavy sticks and shields, they jousted at tent-pegs with lances, shot arrows at small targets while at a full gallop, and trained their horses to stand on their hind legs and jump forward in a manoeuver designed to attack elephants.’ In their spare time the soldiers would have played chess, one of the most common pastimes then.

Near the banks of the Jhelum, Akbar was taken to the top of a steep and craggy hill, the Balnath Thilla, to visit an ancient hermit, the Balnath. From the top of the Thilla the snow-capped Himalayas were clearly visible and far below, at the foot of the hill, the Jhelum sparkled. This extremely venerable religious site, predating by millennia the coming of Guru Gorakhnath, was now the most well-known base of the Kanphata yogis of the country. They derived their name from their custom of splitting the